

CHINA CONSUMER STAPLES

Infant Formula: Tracking consumer sentiment #2; Cabio updates post Nestle IMF recall incident; Friso issue of elevated Lead levels

What's new:

- **Cabio's Profit warning:** Following the [ARA issue in Jan 26](#), [Cabio \(Not Covered\)](#) [stated](#) that due to the severe impact of overseas market public opinion and new regulatory requirements, its production and sales activities have been heavily disrupted. Cabio estimates that normal operations cannot be restored within the next 3 months, triggering the Shanghai Stock Exchange's ST risk warning criteria for operational abnormality (trading of the company's shares [was suspended](#) on July 27, 2026, and resumed on July 28, 2026, under the new stock abbreviation "ST Cabio"). Alongside the risk warning, Cabio released its [preliminary financial forecast](#) for 1H26, showing a decline to a net loss in 1H26 at -c.Rmb101mn. To address this, Cabio's board outlined four primary initiatives while making an effort to establish a comprehensive, full-chain product risk monitoring system to ensure strict compliance with the latest global regulatory standards.

- **Re-engaging Customers:** Prioritizing communication with core clients to restore its non-infant formula "big health" (dietary supplements) business.
- **Diversification:** Accelerating non-ARA segments. In H1 2026, the company secured new large-scale orders for its algal DHA oil in the animal nutrition sector and deepened partnerships with international cosmetics brands.
- **Synthetic Biology Commercialization:** Speeding up the industrialization of Human Milk Oligosaccharides (HMOs). Notably, its lacto-N-neotetraose (LNnT) product recently received regulatory approval from China's National Health Commission.

- **Evolving situation on Friso:** On Jul 25, the Macau government issued a [food safety alert](#) after an inspection which found that one batch of Hong Kong version of FrisoLac Stage 1 IMF product (800g, batch 1W07KPJ) exceeded regulatory Lead limit of 0.02mg/kg. Macau authorities immediately ordered a recall on affected batch and [Hong Kong Centre for Food safety](#) also advised consumers not to use the product. On 26 Jul, China's General Administration of Customs stated that affected batch has not entered mainland China through general trade channels, although consumers who purchased via cross-boarder e-commerce or

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parallel imports were advised to check the batch number. **In response, FrieslandCampina announced that an independent 3rd party lab retested the same batch and found a level of <0.007mg/kg**, well below Macau gov's regulatory limit and the company also stated that all batches of Friso products officially imported into mainland China have undergone full pre-market quality testing with lead consistently reported as non-detected (<0.01mg/kg), well below China's limit of 0.08mg/kg.

- Friesland has been gaining market share in offline IMF market based on Nielsen data in Jan-April 2026, and improved ranking on Douyin in recent 618 shopping festival.
- **Ausnutria (not covered) announced 1H26 profit warning on 24 July**, guiding for Rmb3.07bn-3.17bn revenue (mid point at Rmb3.12bn, down c.20% yoy) and -Rmb685-785 net loss (vs. Rmb181mn net profit in 1H25) due to a combination of phased adjustments and external environmental factors. Excluding a one-time inventory-related adjustment, non-cash asset impairments and other related impacts, Ausnutria expects to record a core net operating profit at Rmb155mn-255mn for 1H26 (mid point at c. Rmb205mn, largely steady yoy). Ausnutria drove a 40% reduction in total supply chain inventory and the compression of channel inventory to under 30 days in 1H26, while the company is also actively streamlining SKUs and optimizing product structures.
 - **Specialized segments:** While standard cow-milk IMF faces intense price competition, specialized segments like goat milk formula (e.g., Kabrita from Hyproca) continue to show robust international growth (particularly in North America and the Middle East).
 - **Beyond Infant Formula:** it is also out "dual-engine" capabilities in professional nutrition and probiotics.

Tracking consumer sentiment: We tracked the Baidu index to gauge consumer sentiment trends on IMF related incidents.

- **For Friso IMF on elevated Lead levels**, Baidu index indicated that a temporary peak of search has already reached on Jul 27th with absolute level much lower than that of Nestle IMF recall (For Nestlé IMF recall on ARA issue with Cabio, Baidu index indicated that this incident cooled down c.20 days post the media reports). Key things to focus on going forward will be further announcements of testing results or related updates from FrieslandCampina /Macau authorities/Mainland China authorities regarding the situation.

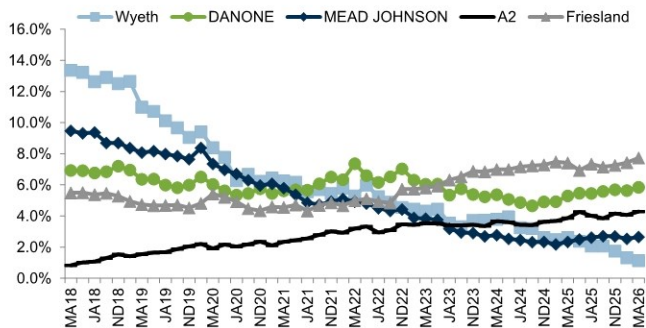
GS view: We believe these reinforce a more cautious near-term sentiment towards the IMF sector (online IMF market sales declined by -17% in 2Q26 and -11% in 1Q26; offline down 8% in Jan-April 2026), while the industry continues to face some headwinds beyond underlying soft demand, incl. supply chain risks/regulatory scrutiny/product quality concerns and ongoing channel adjustments. While these events are largely company/brand specific rather than a systematic disruption in product safety, they are likely to weigh on consumer sentiment and investor confidence in the near-term. We continue to expect leading brands with strong quality control and brand power to gain shares and to be better positioned during the current cycle. **Bellamy and Biostime**

remain the key market share gainers, up 70%/43% yoy in IMF online sales in Jun 2026.

The authors would like to thank Lily Qi for her contribution to this report.

Exhibit 1: MNC players saw sequential market share trend mixed in Mar-Apr, Friesland/Danone/A2 value share increased while Wyeth decreased vs. Jan-Feb

Offline international IMF brands market share by value



Source: Nielsen

Exhibit 2: IMF 618 Shopping festival - Douyin sales ranking by category

IMF		
1	1	Aptamil Danone
2	2	Mengniu Mengniu
4	3	Pro-kido Yili
10	4	AusNuotore M.Love
7	5	Biostime H&H Group
8	6	Friso FrieslandCampina
6	7	Junlebao Junlebao
5	8	A2 A2 Milk
3	9	Firmus China Feihe
>10	10	Adopt A Cow Adopt A Cow

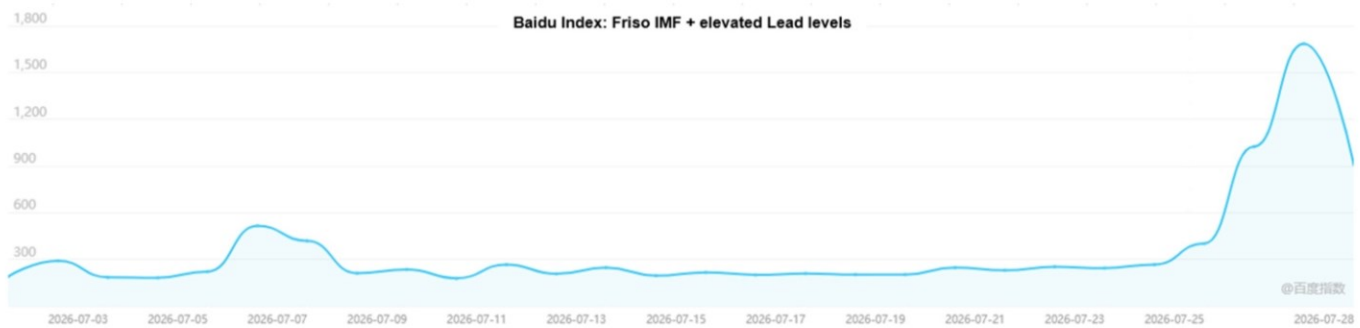
Source: Chanmama, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Tracking Consumer Sentiment

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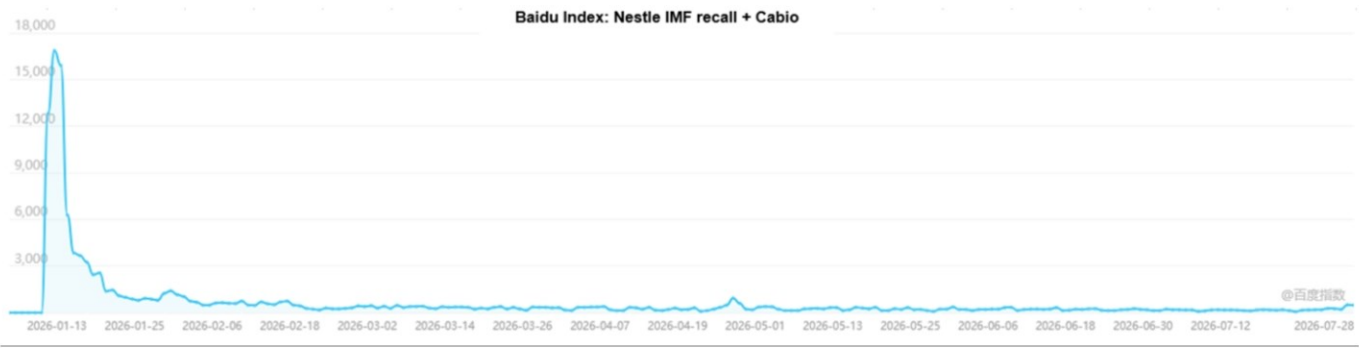
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Exhibit 3: Baidu search index of Friso IMF on elevated Lead levels has reached a temporary peak while still much lower than that of Nestle IMF recall back in Jan 2026



Source: Baidu Index

Exhibit 4: Baidu search index shows that the Nestle IMF recall on ARA issues already cooled down



Source: Baidu index

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